



We departed for Montreal and played some matches according to form. We were locked with Australia in the league with the same number of points, and the replay was decided on penalty strokes. We had lost the first game 6-1 and the replay 5-4 on strokes. At the end of the first match, I made a dreadful decision to end my life. I thought I had let the team down.

We were on the 19th floor, and I just decided to jump from the balcony. I was contemplating hard. Meanwhile, my colleague, Virender Singh, had been watching me and took me inside the room. He spoke to me and talked me out of the decision. I know I would have never been able to make my point had I jumped that day. No one knows about that incident. Not even my family. They will learn about it when they read this interview.

When we returned, there was an inquiry on the letter written to the federation. Some players chickened

out. I suffered because I spoke out against the managers. I was dropped from the team. I decided to prove them wrong. I was recalled for the 1981 World Cup in Bombay as a vice-captain of the team. After that World Cup, I announced my retirement, and I went to the United States to work there for two years.

The locals offered me a green card to enable me to play for the U.S. team in the 1984 Olympics. I could not because my mother forced me to return to India and fixed my marriage.

The astroturf proved a disaster for us. We did not even have helmets, and our protective equipment needed to be of better quality. Our officials were at fault. They needed to take proper measures.

When I came back from Montreal, I had a tough life. People would make fun of me for having conceded six goals. The stigma took time to be erased. It is not easy for a sportsman

in such times. You feel lonely and end up making it tough for yourself.

The Games Village was a unique experience. We had some fantastic athletes. I met Ric Charlesworth and Paul Litjens. Watching Sriram Singh, Srinath Singh, Hari Chand, and T. C. Yohannan was great. It was beautiful as we would meet for breakfast and dinner. We made friends. The boycott of the African nations, however, impacted the atmosphere at the Village. I was also friendly with the Pakistan players.

It took me time to recover from the significant loss to Australia in Montreal. Sometimes, I reflect on those times when goalkeepers were under tremendous pressure. You play well, and they all applaud. You make one mistake, and they savage you. But things improved. I went to the Asian Games as the women's team coach and was honoured with the Dhyanchand Award, the first to win in hockey. I have no regrets.

As told to Vijay Lokapally